At Nigali Sagar Ashoka had expanded the stupa of Konakamana six years earlier: this is recorded over his subsequent visit alongside his worship at the spot and his setting up a pillar.[42] The pillar is now broken, but of the two surviving parts one bears his epigraph. The pillar capital has not survived, Xuanzang's sighting of a lion figure on top of it our only evidence of what it looked like. The emperor may have set up pillars elsewhere in the terai but they have not come to light. As it is, the surviving monoliths provide us a bird's eye view of the pilgrim circuit that then existed around the predecessors of and in relation to the Buddha.

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Ashoka's terai pilgrimage shows a worshipful monarch combining obeisance with a building project that modifies and expands the elements which made up the existing sacred landscape there. He appears in this respect to have been an innovator on a grand scale. The cartography of Buddhism was now subcontinental: the faith was substantially transformed from its original small base in North India. The increased or expanded monumentality of each sacred place also made the individual site much more prominent than it had been, altering regional micro-economies.

This is most evident in the religious architecture of Vaishali. Situated some 29 kms north of Hajipur on the left bank of the Ganga river in Bihar, present-day Basarh has many ruins that can be identified with the ancient city and its suburbs. Ruins and structural remains have also been found in neighbouring villages and areas like Baniya, Charamdas, Lalpura, Virpur, and Kolhua. Vaishali, as we saw, was the Vajji confederacy's bustling capital much before the third century BCE: the Buddha lived many times in it, specifically in the vicinity of Mahavana where the Kutagarshala or hall stood on the banks of the 'Monkey Pool' ('markataharadarira'); and at the monastery in the Amrapalivana, built for him by Vaishali's famous courtesan Amrapali.[43] Because of the Buddha's close association with the